‘Both nations are expected to try to improve their nuclear weapons, increase the explosive force, reliability and variety of types, as far as possible and scientists in both countries could learn better how to do this from further nuclear testing.’

Senior Indian intelligence officers confirmed that the USA had increased its HUMINT collection activities in India. For CIA officials though, Afghanistan and Pakistan were more troublesome and during various meetings in Delhi, the R&AW reminded them that the Taliban and its ally Al-Qaeda were being groomed by Pakistan’s Inter Service Intelligence (ISI) and the USA must act now to prevent inevitable catastrophe. After the hijacking of Indian Airlines Flight 814 and the subsequent open support by the Mullah Omar regime in Afghanistan to Pakistani terrorists, Indian intelligence warned the US government that soon, with the help of the ISI, these terror outfits would become a potent force and may strike beyond Afghan boundaries.

‘I think the Americans listened to us but didn’t believe that terrorists in Afghanistan and certain pockets of Pakistan were a real threat. In our closed-door meetings, some of them raised apprehensions about our analysis and intelligence inputs, terming them too farfetched. Some US officials even observed that our assessment was a by-product of our animosity with Pakistan despite the fact that we gave them proof that the Taliban and Al-Qaeda were being nurtured by the ISI and the state machinery of the neighbouring country,’ said Surendra Sinha, a R&AW officer.

His observation seems plausible. The Americans were watching the Taliban’s growth and the unhindered Pakistani support to hardcore militants from the sidelines. A November 1994 cable